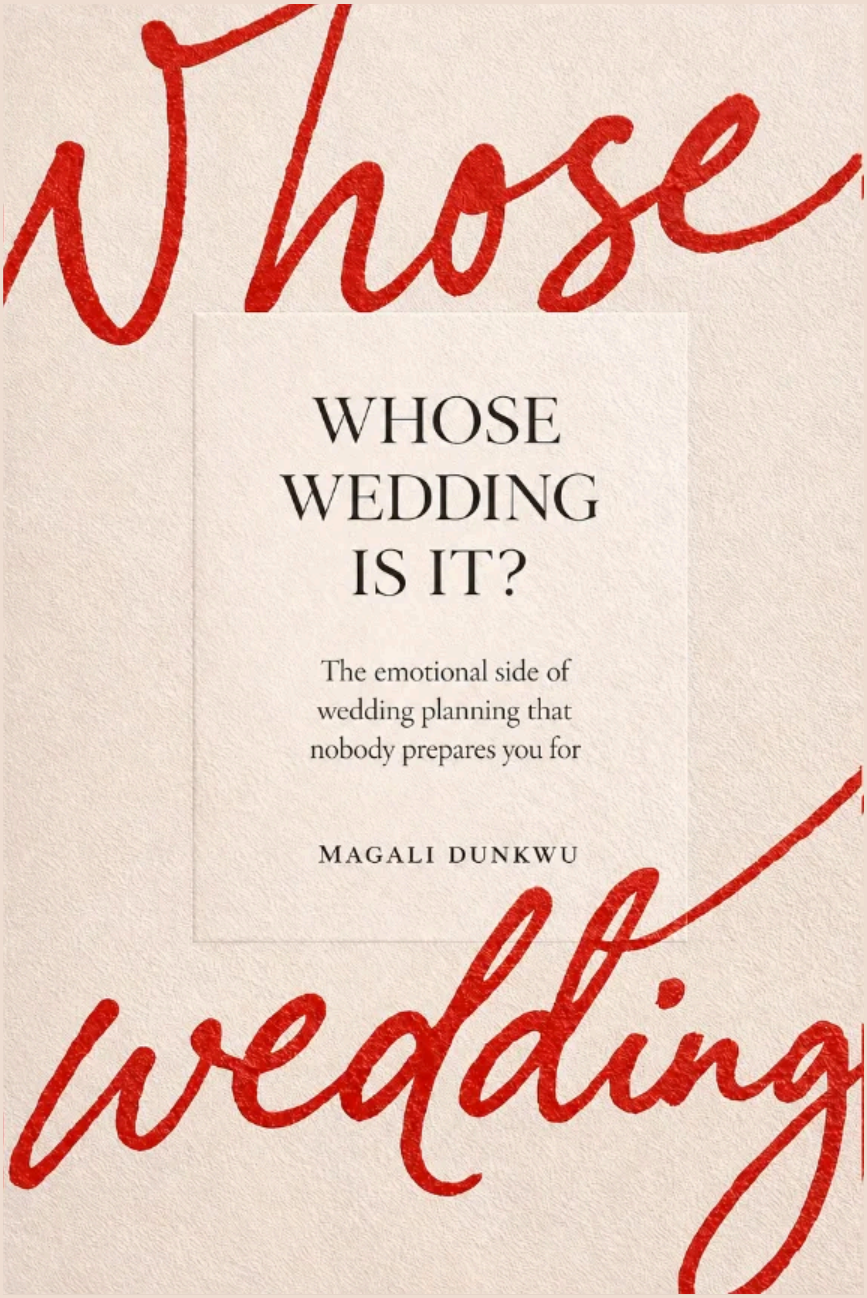
With love

FROM THE GODMOTHER



Free sample · The Introduction & Chapter Five

MAGALI DUNKWU · THE WEDDING GODMOTHER

A NOTE BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Dear you,

If you've found your way here, there's a good chance something has already happened. **A** comment from your mum about the venue. **A**n aunt (there's always an aunt) with views on the guest list. **A** conversation with your partner that went sideways. Maybe it's simply a quiet feeling that the wedding has stopped being entirely yours.

You're not imagining it, and you're not alone.

I've spent years planning weddings, and what I've learnt is that the part that catches couples off guard is rarely the flowers or the seating plan. It's the people, the money and the feelings. Nobody prepares you for that, so I wrote the book that does.

I've chosen these two pieces for you on purpose. The Introduction asks the question at the heart of everything: whose wedding is it, really? Chapter Five, Family Matters, is the one couples tell me they needed most, because weddings don't create family tensions. They reveal them.

Use the worksheet. Have the conversation that feels a little uncomfortable. That's where the real preparation for marriage happens.

So grab a pen, pour yourself a cup of tea, and let's begin.

With love,

Magali

THE WEDDING GODMOTHER

weddinggodmother.co.uk

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Introduction

Whose wedding is it, really?

It sounds like a simple question. You'd think the answer is obvious: it's yours: yours and your partner's. You're the ones who fell in love, you're the ones who said yes, and you're the ones who'll stand in front of your loved ones and make promises to each other.

But the moment that ring goes on your finger, something interesting happens. Suddenly, everybody has a stake in your big day. Your mum has opinions about the venue. Your dad has views on the guest list. Your aunt (there's always an aunt) has strong feelings about traditions that absolutely must be observed. Your best friend is hurt that you're considering someone else for maid of honour. **A**nd your partner? Well, it turns out they've been imagining something entirely different from what you had in mind.

Welcome to wedding planning.

I love weddings. I've spent years planning them, helping couples handle the lovely chaos of turning a dream day into reality. **A**nd what I've learnt, time and again, is this: what catches couples off guard isn't the logistics. It's not finding the right florist or choosing between chicken and fish. It's the emotional side. The family tensions that surface out of nowhere. Those friendships that shift under pressure. The arguments about money that neither of you saw coming, and the silent moments of doubt that creep in at 2 am.

That's what this book is about.

You won't find advice here on how to fold napkins into swans. There are plenty of books and endless Pinterest boards for that. What you will find is an honest, practical guide to the emotional journey of planning a wedding: the part that nobody prepares you for, but that determines whether you actually enjoy the process or simply survive it.

What Makes This Book Different

This is a guidebook, not just a book. It's designed to be used, not just read. Throughout each chapter, you'll find reflection prompts and conversation starters: moments where I'll ask you to pause, think, and talk to your partner. **A**t the end of each chapter, there's a worksheet section called "Over to You" where you can work through the ideas together. Write in these sections. Be honest. Have the conversations that feel a little uncomfortable. That's where the real preparation for marriage happens.

And if your partner won't do the worksheets with you? Don't force it — but don't ignore it either. Do the solo reflections, note which conversations you couldn't have, and know that the gap itself is telling you something worth gently raising. This book works at whatever level of participation you can get.

Who Is This Book For?

Anyone planning a wedding, no matter your budget, background, or ceremony style. Whether you're organising a lavish celebration or an intimate gathering, the emotional challenges are remarkably similar. Parents still have opinions. Money still causes stress. Friendships still get tested. **A**nd at some point, most couples ask themselves the same quiet question: are we doing this right?

If you're in the middle of planning and feeling overwhelmed, this book is for you. If you haven't started yet and want to go in with your eyes open, it's for you too.

How to Use This Book

The chapters follow a natural arc, from the first excitement through the emotional challenges and out the other side. Read it cover to cover, or dip into whichever chapter feels most relevant to where you are right now.

We start with the emotional stages of planning: a roadmap for the feelings you're likely to experience, so you can recognise them when they arrive. Then, before a single budget or guest list, we sit with the question that matters more than any of them: are you sure? From there, we tackle the subject beneath almost every wedding disagreement — money — and then move through the people in your life (your partner, your family, your friends, your vendors) and how to navigate those relationships without losing yourself or your temper. **A**nd we finish with your dream wedding: how to hold onto your vision while making room for the compromises that real life demands.

One thing before we begin. Everything in this book comes from weddings I've actually seen — but they're realities I've witnessed, not predictions for yours. Your family may never feud. Your friends may be flawless. If a chapter doesn't match your life, skip it with my blessing and count yourself fortunate. It will be there if things change.

Throughout it all, we'll keep returning to that central question: whose wedding is it? The answer, as you'll discover, is more nuanced than you might think.

So grab a pen, pour yourself a cup of tea, and let's begin.

Magali

REFLECTION PROMPT

*Before you read any further, answer this honestly: when you picture your wedding day, what do you see? **A**nd does your partner see the same thing? If you haven't asked them yet, now's a good time.*

My Wedding Vision

Give yourself room here. There are no wrong answers: this space is yours.

SOLO REFLECTION

1. My Wedding Vision

In a couple sentences, describe your ideal wedding day.

SOLO REFLECTION, THEN COMPARE

2. My Partner's Wedding Vision

***A**sk your partner to do the same, separately. Compare afterwards.*

COUPLE CONVERSATION

3. What Matters Most

List your three non-negotiables for the wedding.

i. ii. iii.

COUPLE CONVERSATION

4. Who Has a Stake?

Keep this rough — we'll come back to it properly in the family chapter.

PERSON	THEIR LIKELY PRIORITY OR CONCERN

COUPLE CONVERSATION

5. Our Agreement

***A**s a couple, agree on one sentence that captures your shared intention for the planning process.*

Chapter Five

Family Matters

Check in: where are you on the rollercoaster today? Tick one, no judgement.

☐ EXCITEMENT ☐ REALITY ☐ STRESS ☐ DISAPPOINTMENT

☐ FRUSTRATION ☐ PANIC ☐ ACCEPTANCE ☐ JOY

Is there a family with no issues? I haven't met one yet — though perhaps yours is the exception. Some families genuinely do sail through weddings, and if that's you, read this chapter lightly and count your blessings. For everyone else: families are made up of individuals with different characters, temperaments, and wounds: the generous and the difficult, the caring and the interfering. **A**nd these are the same people who'll be at your wedding.

If navigating your own family weren't enough, you're also merging with another one. **A** wedding doesn't just join two people. It brings two entire worlds into the same room and asks them to celebrate together.

PAUSE AND REFLECT

Who in your family landscape is most likely to have strong opinions or cause friction? Hold those names in mind as you read.

Culture, Tradition, and the Modern Wedding

Every culture has wedding traditions, and some sound wonderfully eccentric to outsiders. In some parts of the world, guests smash porcelain plates on the floor, and the newly married couple must sweep up every shard together before entering their home. In others, the ceremony must happen at the bride's family house, or the groom's, depending on who you ask. There's even a tradition where the couple eats chocolate from a toilet bowl. (Yes, really.)

And yet weddings are constantly evolving. The white dress and the multi-tiered cake weren't essentials a few generations ago; the pre-wedding shoot didn't exist at all until recently, and now couples spend small fortunes posing for cameras. What feels timeless is often newer than we think, which is worth remembering when someone insists a trend is a tradition. The challenge is honouring where you've come from while creating something that feels authentically yours.

Start with a conversation between the two of you. Map out the cultural expectations on both sides before involving anyone else. Which traditions do you feel genuinely connected to, and which feel like obligations? You don't want your partner blindsided by a tradition they weren't expecting, and you certainly don't want your in-laws reading you as someone who doesn't respect their culture.

Be honest about what you're comfortable with. If aspects of either culture don't sit right with you, say so: to each other first, then, if necessary, to the relevant family members. Rejecting a tradition outright can feel like rejecting the people who hold it dear, so explain your position with consideration, and where possible recommend an alternative that honours the spirit of the tradition even while it adapts the form.

And when cultures genuinely clash, approach both families with a spirit of inclusion. Weave elements from both worlds into the day so neither side feels erased. If a true impasse arises, you and your partner decide together and present a united front. This is where the question in the center of this book gets very real: whose wedding is it? Yours. Both of yours.

Family Feuds: The Tensions Weddings Expose

Here's something I've learnt from years of standing at the back of wedding receptions: weddings don't create family tensions. They reveal them. The issues were already there (buried, ignored, politely sidestepped at every Christmas), and the ceremony simply gives them a stage and an audience.

"Weddings don't create family tensions. They reveal them."

Some family members won't even realise they're doing it. Big occasions stir things up in people. The cousin who drinks too much at the reception might be masking loneliness. The parent who tries to control every detail might be struggling to let go. None of this excuses bad behaviour, but understanding it helps you plan for it instead of being blindsided.

Because here's something I've learnt over the years: people don't grow out of their issues. They grow with them. The grudge that's been buried for a decade doesn't disappear. It waits for an occasion. **A**nd weddings, like funerals, are exactly the kind of occasion it waits for.

FROM THE PLANNER'S DIARY

The Son Who Met His Mother

One of my grooms called me during the planning, genuinely shaken. His mother's behaviour had become difficult (demanding, emotional, creating tension at every decision) and he could not understand it. This was his mum. The woman who had done everything for him.

Confused, he went to other family members to ask what was going on. Their response floored him: "Yeah, that's the way she is." Everyone knew. **A**unts, uncles, cousins: they had all seen this side of her for years. Everyone except him. He had only ever seen her through a son's eyes, and she had only ever shown him her best self. Faced with an emotionally charged event she couldn't control, she became the person the rest of the family had always known.

It hurt him deeply, and for a while it consumed him. His whole head was full of it at exactly the moment he wanted to be full of joy.

I share this because it's more common than you'd think: wedding planning shows many people a side of their parents they've never had to see. If it happens to you, you're not alone, and it isn't your fault. Catch it as early as you can, talk to someone, and put support around yourself, because you deserve to walk into your wedding with a clear head and a full heart.

Magali

So start early. Sit down with your partner and be honest about both families. Who might behave unpredictably? Who hasn't spoken to whom since that thing at your brother's christening? This isn't paranoia; it's preparation, and it's the difference between a couple who handle a wobble gracefully and a couple caught off guard at their own reception.

If you know there's a problem, deal with it now, not on the day. Talk to the people involved, or ask someone they respect to do it for you. "I love you, and I want you there, but I need to know you can be supportive on the day" is a fair thing to ask of any adult.

And here's the part I insist on with every couple I work with: you should not be the one handling family tensions on your wedding day. You have one job that day: to marry the person you love and enjoy every minute of it. Choose someone with a cool head, brief them properly, and hand the whole thing over. That's not avoidance. That's intelligent delegation.

"That's not avoidance. That's intelligent delegation."

Divorced parents and blended families

This deserves its own mention because it's so common and so delicate. Speak to each parent separately and candidly. Tell them what your dream for the day looks like with both of them in it. Then get specific about the particular details: who walks you down the aisle, where everyone sits, who appears in which photographs. These questions feel trivial until they cause tears on the day. Settle them in advance.

Speaking Up

For some readers, the hardest part of this chapter isn't a specific feud. It's a lifetime of never having had a voice in their own family. If decisions have always been made for you, asserting yourself now, on something this visible, can feel terrifying.

I want to encourage you, gently but firmly, to find that voice. **A**s someone about to build a life with another person, it's time to speak your mind on the things that concern your future. Not aggressively: clearly, honestly, kindly. Pick your battles wisely; not every hill is worth dying on. But on the things that really matter to you and your partner, stand your ground with grace.

Hold both truths at once, though. Yes, it's your wedding — the decisions are yours and your partner's, and they stay that way. But the day matters to other people too. Your mother has imagined it for years. Your uncle has been saving a story for the toast. The ones making time from their busy lives to support you deserve to be considered: not obeyed, but considered. That balance is the whole art of this.

"Not obeyed, but considered."

And for the truly complicated situations, where the tensions run so deep that no amount of delegation or diplomacy will hold, there is always one more option: an intimate wedding with immediate family only. It's not a defeat. For some couples, it's the wisest, most peaceful decision they make.

The Empty Chair

Some of you are planning a wedding around an absence. **A** parent who should have walked you down the aisle. **A** grandmother who prayed for this day and didn't see it. If that's you, know that grief has a way of arriving at weddings uninvited — often in the planning, sometimes on the morning itself — and it doesn't mean anything is wrong. It means someone mattered.

Decide together, and early, how you want to hold them: a reading, a candle, a flower on an empty seat, a quiet word between the two of you before you walk in — or nothing visible at all, just their name held privately between you. There is no correct amount of tribute. Some couples need the acknowledgement out loud; others find a public moment too heavy for a day already full. Both are love.

One practical kindness: tell your officiant and whoever is holding the day together. Not so they make it a theme — so that if the wave arrives mid-ceremony, someone is holding the room while you hold each other.

Keeping Perspective

Your wedding means different things to different people. To you it's a beginning; to your parents it might feel like an ending. Understanding that people's behaviour is often driven by their own fears and longings helps you respond with compassion, not anger.

The family's dirty linen doesn't have to be aired in public. But it does need to be washed better now, on your terms, than on the day itself.

Family opinions are only the beginning, though. Once word gets out, everyone has a view. **A**nd I mean everyone.

In the full book, this chapter closes with its own "Over to You" worksheet: your Family Map, a Wobble Plan, and the lines you'll hold together. *See what else is inside →*

There's more

What's in the full book

— Introduction — IN THIS SAMPLE · P.3

01 The Emotional Stages of Planning
There's a saying that nothing good comes easy, and wedding planning is no exception.

02 Having Cold Feet?
Before the venues, the budgets, and the guest lists, let's talk about something we don't discuss nearly enough: doubt.

03 The Financial Aspect of Wedding Planning
Weddings run on money.

04 Your Partner
Here is something that gets lost with surprising ease during wedding planning: there are two of you in this.

05 Family Matters — IN THIS SAMPLE · P.8

06 Opinions
When it comes to your wedding, everybody will have an opinion.

07 Friends
***A**fter family, the next group of people who can cause unexpected heartache are your friends.*

08 Vendor Relationships
Your wedding vendors are not the enemy.

09 Your Dream Wedding
Planning starts in the mind. There's no way to build something your imagination hasn't first sketched out.

— Conclusion
Whose wedding is it?

Plus: My Wedding Notes · With Thanks · **A**bout the **A**uthor · Stay Close. Every chapter ends with an "Over to You" worksheet.

OUT 27 NOVEMBER 2026

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